



Steve Jobs' obsession

design of the icon packs of the early iPhones (think of the compass, or the metronome app). However, it came with its fair share of drawbacks (discussed later), which led to a number of design faux pas, like the infamous Apple DVD player.

The Good, the Bad and the Ugly

To understand skeuomorphism in depth, it is a good idea to start with the basics. Skeuomorphism is essentially mimicking the appearance of real life objects. Skeuomorphic design is not a new idea. The earliest instances of skeuomorphism can be seen in everyday life even today. Think of plastic chairs. They mimic the functionality of traditional wooden chairs, and also their shape and design. Similarly, when the GUI was invented, plenty of time, money, and pixels were invested into mimicking the shapes, textures and behavior of everyday materials. Some of the commonly used textures mimicked the appearance of stone, leather, paper, fabric and wood. Apple products lavishly used these textures, and have even faced criticism for over using leather textures in their apps.

The argument for skeuomorphism is driven for the most part by one key word: familiarity. Since skeuomorphic designs mimic real world objects, it immediately becomes obvious to the user what the functionality of a particular product is. For example, since the calendar app on the iPhone looked like an actual calendar, complete with animations for turning pages, it was quite obvious that it was a calendar. Another appeal of skeuomor-